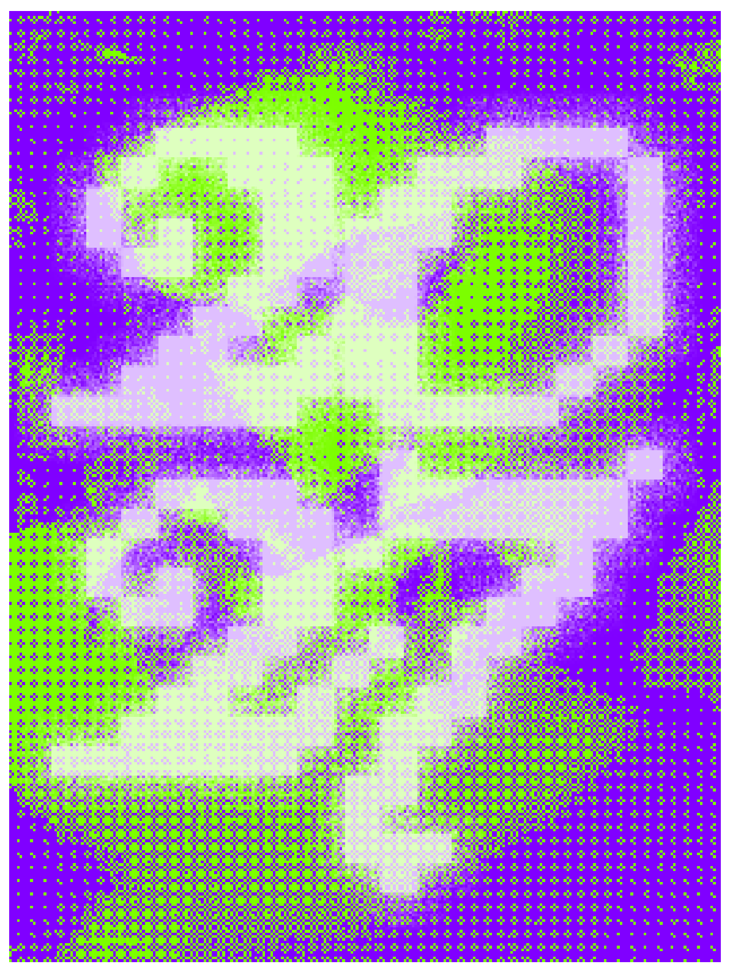
MELBOURNE CINÉMATHÈQUE



Wednesdays at acmi
Fed Square, Naarm

4-18 FEBRUARY

"You Can Never Go Fast Enough"

Although it is a genre that has taken hold in other countries such as Australia, the road movie is most keenly associated with American cinema. Taking its cue from the forward momentum of colonialism, conquest and the wandering search for meaning that characterise the Western, and the development of the vast network of highways and byways that crisscross the United States with the coming of modernity and the motor car, the road movie can be regarded – along with the Western – as the quintessential American genre. Mixing with comedy, crime, romance and other genres, it took particular hold with the coming of sound. Although often categorised in other ways, such celebrated films as Frank Capra's It Happened One Night (1934), Joseph H. Lewis' Gun Crazy (1950) and John Ford's The Searchers (1956) can be productively understood as archetypal or formative "road" movies.

But it is in the late 1960s and early 1970s that the road movie reached its apogee, in the aftershock of the extraordinary popular success of Dennis Hopper's Easy Rider (1969) and Hollywood studios' newfound openness to emerging talent with a very different outlook on cinema and life. The forward momentum of earlier films is hollowed out, as movies like Five Easy Pieces (1970) and Two-Lane Blacktop (1971) reflect the relentless, cyclical but questing motion of burned out, listless yet idealistic figures across a blighted and lost American landscape. In many ways the road movie is the model genre of New Hollywood and the counterculture, and for a few short years it was a dominant expressive force. This season focuses on the first half of the 1970s and highlights the importance of the road movie form to key emerging filmmakers such as Terrence Malick, Bob Rafelson, Monte Hellman and Steven Spielberg. It also includes singular works like Barbara Loden's remarkable sole feature, Wanda (1970), and the iconic, genre-defining Vanishing Point (1971).

4 FEBRUARY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

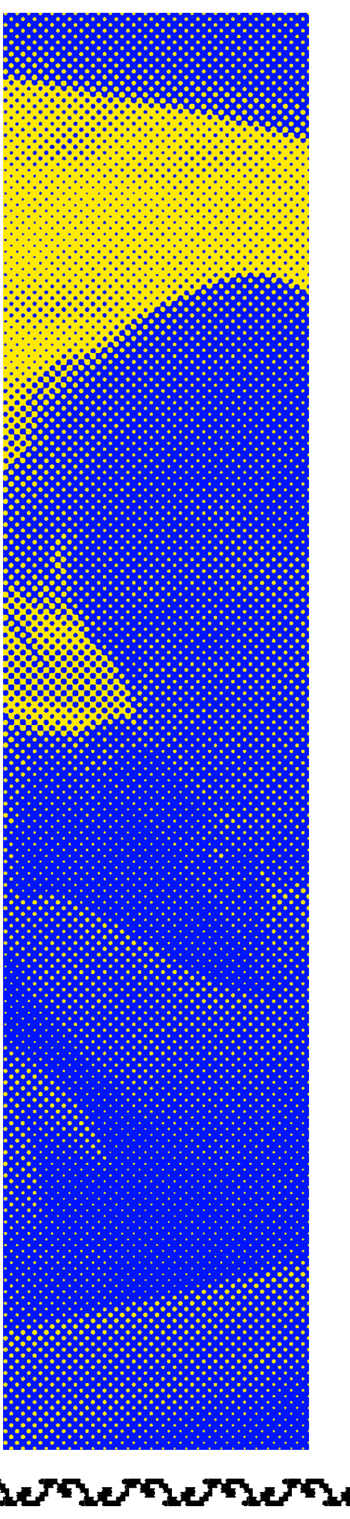
TWO-LANE BLACKTOP
Monte Hellman (1971) 102 mins – M

This aphoristic and metaphysical road movie charts the meandering race between a Pontiac GTO and a stripped back 1955 Chevy across a blighted post-1960s America. One of the defining works of the road movie genre, Hellman's commercially underperforming opus quickly became a key cult movie. A profound essay on aimlessness, ennui and car culture, it marshals suitably naturalistic and bracingly low-key performances from Laurie Bird and rock stars James Taylor and Dennis Wilson. It also allows space for one of Warren Oates' most soulful and iconic turns ("If I'm not grounded pretty soon, I'm gonna go into orbit"). With Harry Dean Stanton.

9:00 pm

BADLANDS
Terrence Malick (1973) 94 mins – M

A cool, philosophical and troublingly American neo-noir based on the real-life murder spree by Charles Starkweather across Nebraska and Wyoming in the late 1950s. Malick's critically acclaimed, stylistically distinct and extraordinarily controlled directorial debut channels an emerging "TV generation" of disaffected American teens blithely seeking instant thrills and fame. In her breakthrough performance, Sissy Spacek inhabits the character of 15-year-old Holly, whose disarming voiceover matter-of-factly "recounts" the murderous actions of Kit (Martin Sheen, in a career-defining role). With Warren Oates.



11 FEBRUARY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

THE SUGARLAND EXPRESS
Steven Spielberg (1974) 110 mins

Based on real lovers-on-the-lam Ila Fae Holiday and Bobby Dent, Spielberg's assured and riotous theatrical debut stars Goldie Hawn as a woman breaking her husband (William Atherton) out of prison in order for the pair to retrieve their son from child welfare services. Spurred by the extraordinary success of his 1971 TV movie Duel, the film initiated Spielberg's collaborations with cinematographer Vilmos Zsigmond, who delicately captures the sun-dazzled Texan landscape during numerous chaotic car chases, and composer John Williams, whose soundtrack features famed harmonica player Toots Thielemans. With Ben Johnson.

4K DCP.

9:05 pm

VANISHING POINT
Steven Spielberg (1974) 110 mins

Propelled by speed-induced mysticism and burning countercultural sentiments, Kowalski, a loner and car delivery driver played by a then largely unknown Barry Newman, races through a disaffected America in a white Dodge Challenger trying to escape the powers that be. Although critically panned upon its initial release, the film steadily reached cult classic status, being affectionately referenced by the likes of Quentin Tarantino, Edgar Wright and Primal Scream (on their 1997 album Vanishing Point). Scripted by the legendary Cuban novelist and critic Guillermo Cabrera Infante (as Guillermo Cain), it also features Dean Jagger and Cleavon Little.

18 FEBRUARY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

WANDA
Barbara Loden (1970) 102 mins – Unclassified 15

Loden's first and only feature as writer-director – she also stars as the title character – is a bracing portrait of alienated working-class womanhood. The film was shot on location in Pennsylvania and Connecticut with a crew of around seven people, and its realist and partially improvised style was acclaimed upon release, winning the International Critics' Prize at the Venice Film Festival. Loden's uncompromising portrayal of a woman down and out was inspired by her own feelings of aimlessness, and is now considered a key work of American independent cinema, feminist filmmaking and the 1970s road movie.

35mm print courtesy of the UCLA Film & Television Archive.

8:55 pm

FIVE EASY PIECES
Steven Spielberg (1974) 110 mins – M

A cool, philosophical and troublingly American neo-noir based on the real-life murder spree by Charles Starkweather across Nebraska and Wyoming in the late 1950s. Malick's critically acclaimed, stylistically distinct and extraordinarily controlled directorial debut channels an emerging "TV generation" of disaffected American teens blithely seeking instant thrills and fame. In her breakthrough performance, Sissy Spacek inhabits the character of 15-year-old Holly, whose disarming voiceover matter-of-factly "recounts" the murderous actions of
Kit (Martin Sheen, in a career-defining role).
With Warren Oates.

MELBOURNE CINÉMATHÈQUE

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The Melbourne Cinémathèque 2026 Season

Curated By: Michael Koller, Adrian Danks, Eloise Ross, Cerise Howard and Andréas Giannopoulos for the Melbourne Cinémathèque

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25-11 FEBRUARY-MARCH

Tales of Modern Love: Leos Carax, Rebirthing Cinema

Though the often-fraught and meticulous creative process of Leos Carax (1960–) has resulted in the production of only six features and a handful of shorts, the fabulist French writer-director's imagination, sincerity and acknowledgement of the unknowable has remained consistent across his 45-year career.

Born Alex Christophe Dupont, Carax announced his unconventionality early in life by changing his name at the age of 13. Often non-verbal as a teenager, he became fascinated with silent film while attending the Cinémathèque française. After a handful of aborted projects and a brief stint with Cahiers du cinéma, he completed the dreamlike short Strangulation Blues (1980), and gained international attention with the equally nocturnal feature Boy Meets Girl (1984).

Categorised as part of the cinéma du look movement due to his work's bold aesthetics, Carax diverges from contemporaries Luc Besson and Jean-Jacques Beineix through his interest in pre- and early cinema, referencing and channelling the explorations of photographer Eadweard Muybridge and maintaining a creatively codependent relationship with theatre and circus performer Denis Lavant. His cinema is also characterised by a desperate search for genuine romance that bled into his off-screen relationships with a number of featured actresses: Mireille Perrier, Juliette Binoche and Katerina Golubeva. The essential Carax moments combine magic and love, such as in Mauvais sang (1986) when Lavant, attempting to woo Binoche, throws a single apple off-screen, only for a barrage of other food to rain down on him.

More recently, the filmmaker has reflected on the death and rebirth of cinema through new forms of motion-capture and digital video in Holy Motors (2012), and the adoption of the traditional forms of opera and puppetry in Annette (2021). This season presents most of Carax's singular body of work,
including the extravagant Les amants du Pont-Neuf (1991), the rarely seen extended miniseries version of 1999's Pola X, Pierre ou les ambiguïtiés (2001), and the recent self-portrait It's Not Me (2024), chronicling an outsider who paradoxically remains at the centre of late-20th and early-21st-century cinema.

25 FEBRUARY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

LES AMANTS DU PONT-NEUF
Leos Carax (1991) 126 mins – M

Alex (Denis Lavant) is an amateur circus performer addicted to sedatives. Michèle (Juliette Binoche) is a painter haunted by a failed relationship and an affliction which is gradually making her blind. Set primarily on Paris' oldest bridge, the Pont-Neuf, Carax's feverish love story blends elemental imagery and documentary components to powerful effect. With its extraordinary set pieces shot during France's 1989 Bicentennial celebrations, Jonathan Rosenbaum declared it "the great urban expressionist fantasy of the '90s". With Edith Scob.

35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

9:25 pm

MAUVAIS SANG
Leos Carax (1986) 116 mins – Unclassified 15+

Often described as a neo-noir, this romantically exhilarating and stylish science-fiction thriller almost defies categorisation. Juliette Binoche and Denis Lavant give remarkable performances as beautiful, desperate lovers in a delirious, alienating, nocturnal Paris. The film features an iconic soundtrack including music by Benjamin Britten and David Bowie, but Jonathan Rosenbaum likened Carax's style to that of silent cinema, "with its melancholy, its innocence, its poetics of close-up, gesture, and the mysteries of personality". Co-starring Michel Piccoli, Julie Delpy, Mireille Perrier and Serge Reggiani.

4 MARCH
Wednesday

7:00 pm

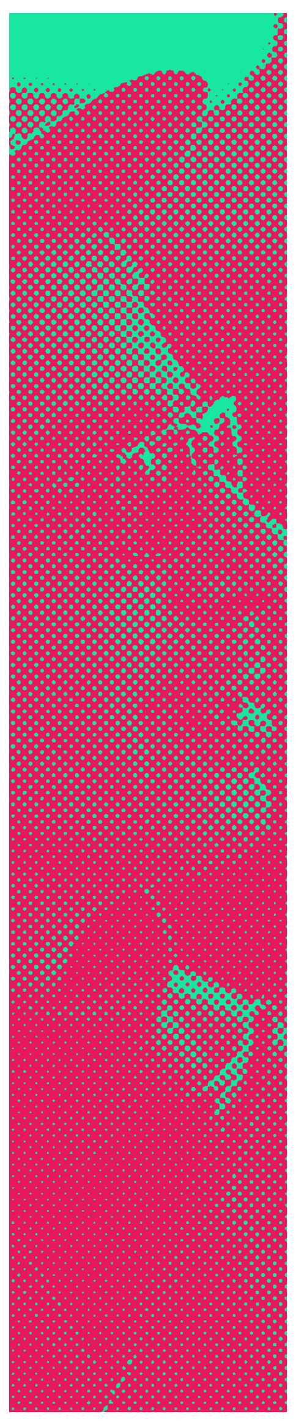
IT'S NOT ME
Leos Carax (2024) 41 mins – Unclassified 15+

Responding to the Centre Pompidou's prompt, "Where are you at, Leos Carax?", this "self-portrait seen from behind" explores the filmmaker's work and influence against the legacies of postwar Europe. Told mainly through a collage of narration and archival materials, Carax's Godard-Miéville-inspired essay film also includes new scenes featuring his daughter Nastya Golubeva Carax, Denis Lavant and the director himself. Preceded by My Last Minute Leos Carax (2006) 1 min – Unclassified 15+. A haunting and hilarious trailer made for the 44th Viennale.

7:55pm

PIERRE OU, LES AMBIGUÏTÉS
Leos Carax (2001) 174 mins – Unclassified 18+

Propelled by speed-induced mysticism and burning countercultural sentiments, Kowalski, a loner and car delivery driver played by a then largely unknown Barry Newman, races through a disaffected America in a white Dodge Challenger trying to escape the powers that be. Although critically panned upon its initial release, the film steadily reached cult classic status, being affectionately referenced by the likes of Quentin Tarantino, Edgar Wright and Primal Scream (on their 1997 album Vanishing Point). Scripted by the legendary Cuban novelist and critic Guillermo Cabrera Infante (as Guillermo Cain), it also features Dean Jagger and Cleavon Little.



11 MARCH
Wednesday

7:00 pm

HOLY MOTORS
Leos Carax (2012) 116 mins – MA 15+

Loden's first and only feature as writer-director – she also stars as the title character – is a bracing portrait of alienated working-class womanhood. The film was shot on location in Pennsylvania and Connecticut with a crew of around seven people, and its realist and partially improvised style was acclaimed upon release, winning the International Critics' Prize at the Venice Film Festival. Loden's uncompromising portrayal of a woman down and out was inspired by her own feelings of aimlessness, and is now considered a key work of American independent cinema, feminist filmmaking and the 1970s road movie.

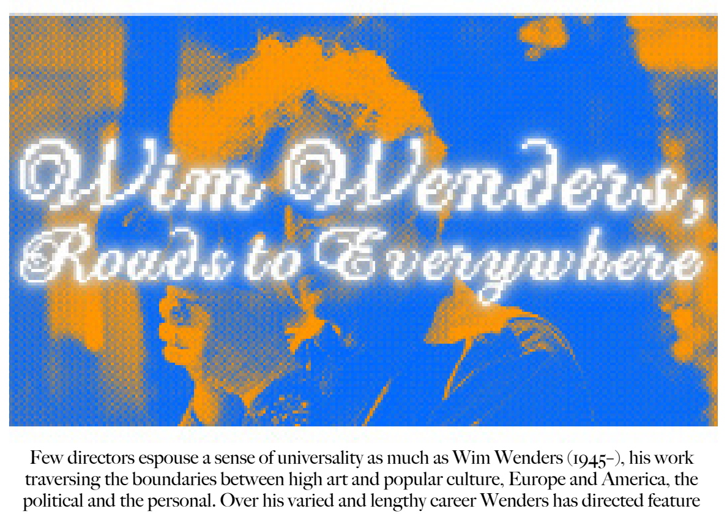
35mm print courtesy of the UCLA Film & Television Archive.

8:55 pm

BOY MEETS GIRL
Leos Carax (1984) 100 mins – Unclassified 15+

Marking the first collaboration between the director and his key muse Denis Lavant, Carax's debut feature is a deft study of youthful ennui on the streets of Paris. Only in his early 20s at the time of filming, the extraordinary clarity of Carax's determined vision belied his young age. Inspired by the youthful works of the nouvelle vague, while connected to, but distinct from, the other films of the cinéma du look movement, Carax's film is filled with a burning vigour embodied by the strikingly luminous black-and-white cinematography of Jean-Yves Escoffier (a key collaborator who shot Carax's first three features). With Mireille Perrier.

18-1 MARCH - APRIL



Wim Wenders, Roads to Everywhere

Few directors espouse a sense of universality as much as Wim Wenders (1945–), his work traversing the boundaries between high art and popular culture, Europe and America, the political and the personal. Over his varied and lengthy career Wenders has directed feature films, documentaries, shorts and music videos, all challenging the spectator with beautiful, open imagery while being equally aware of the fundamental need for some kind of narrative propulsion.
Wenders began alongside other luminaries such as Werner Herzog, Alexander Kluge and Rainer Werner Fassbinder as part of the New German Cinema in the late 1960s. Setting his work apart from his compatriots, he draws inspiration most frequently from genre films, looking back to Weimar-era cinema and outwards to the Hollywood iconography of John Ford, Samuel Fuller and Nicholas Ray. An equal devotion to the work of Michelangelo Antonioni and Yasujiro Ozu provides a sense of sublime ambiguity to Wenders' cinema.

His more narratively conventional films of the 1980s onwards, such as Paris, Texas (1984) and Wings of Desire (1987), attracted both awards and celebrity, resulting in collaborations with an array of cutting-edge artists across numerous disciplines. Despite his predominant use of unadorned and stark locations, Wenders has also kept abreast of digital innovations, including groundbreaking 3D explorations (such as his extraordinary tribute to Pina Bausch).

Embracing a filmmaker who is intellectually restless, emotionally involved and utterly devoted to the medium, this season surveys a number of Wenders' key works of the 1970s and 1980s. It includes his breakthrough feature, The Goalkeeper's Fear of the Penalty (1972), his fascinating B-movie homage, The State of Things (1982), and his masterpieces, Kings of the Road (1976) and Wings of Desire.

18 MARCH
Wednesday

7:00 pm

KINGS OF THE ROAD
Wim Wenders (1976) 175 mins - R18+

Wenders' now-classic buddy movie is an elliptical road odyssey of two estranged men (Rüdiger Vogler and Hanns Zischler) traversing the nether regions of the East/West German border while servicing broken-down movie theatres. Powered by an idiosyncratic mix of 1960s pop music (heard and quoted by the characters) and Axel Lindstädt's evocative score, Wenders' existential narrative poetically charts the Americanisation of the German mindscape, the impoverishment and beauty of the stark modern landscape, and the inevitable death of the cinema. The final part of the director's "road trilogy" following the previous year's Wrong Move. With Lisa Kreuzer.

4K DCP.

10:15 pm

CHAMBRE 666
Wim Wenders (1982) 48 mins - M

An intriguing time capsule in which Wenders asks various filmmakers to enter a hotel room, turn on the camera and answer the "simple" question: "Is the cinema a language about to get lost, an art about to die?" Filmed at the 1982 Cannes Film Festival, it features candid and playful responses from Michelangelo Antonioni, Jean-Luc Godard, Werner Herzog, Steven Spielberg, Monte Hellman, Mike De Leon, Susan Seidelman, Yilmaz Güney, Rainer Werner Fassbinder and others. Preceded by Reverse Angle: Ein Brief aus New York Wim Wenders (1982) 17 mins – Unclassified 15+. Wenders' essay film about New Wave music, New York, his artistic practice and the difficulties of working with Francis Ford Coppola on Hammett.

25 MARCH
Wednesday

7:00 pm

WRONG MOVE
Wim Wenders (1975) 175 mins - R18+

The Bildungsroman originated in the late 18th century, commonly following a young protagonist who goes out into the world seeking personal development and education. Although Goethe's 1795 Bildungsroman Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship was the basis for Peter Handke's screenplay, Wenders' Wilhelm (Rüdiger Vogler) traverses contemporary Germany with a resigned, post-1960s pessimism, encountering the potent spectres of Germany's past. This is contrasted with the rich images of the land itself, from the glistening Elbe River in northern Germany to the snowy Zugspitze mountain in the south. Co-starring Hanna Schygulla and featuring Nastassja Kinski in her debut film role.

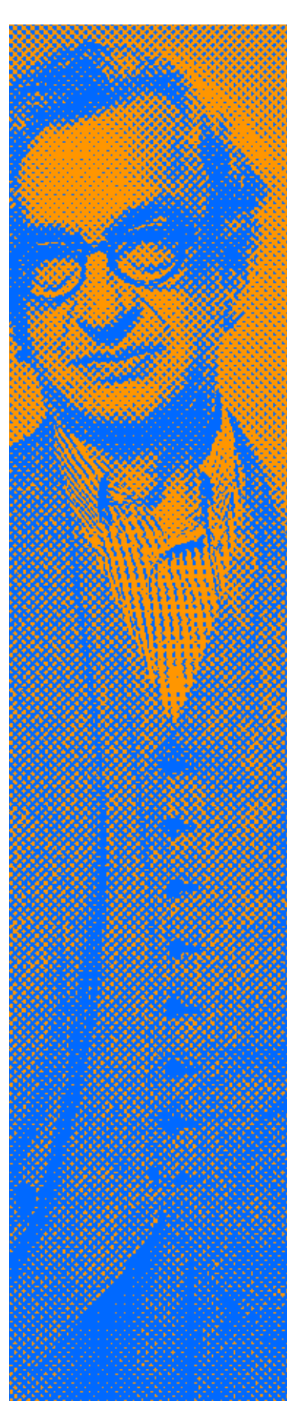
4K DCP.

8:55 pm

THE GOALKEEPER'S FEAR OF THE PENALTY
Wim Wenders (1972) 101 mins – Unclassified 15+

Adapting Peter Handke's short novel, Wenders delivers a drifter's-eye view of paranoia and dissociation, shaped by his fascination with the way people move through the world when their inner compass has slipped. Following its titular, murderous protagonist (Arthur Brauss) with dispassionate curiosity, letting behaviour reveal more than psychology, the film's uncanny calm owes as much to Robby Müller's sun-bleached, quietly dislocated images as to Handke's dry, clipped dialogue – a combination that keeps everything slightly off balance, as if it were the world itself that was misfiring.

4K DCP.



1 APRIL
Wednesday

7:00 pm

WINGS OF DESIRE
Wim Wenders (1987) 128 mins – PG

An angel (Bruno Ganz) soulfully watching over the stranded citizens of West Berlin is tempted by the pleasures of the flesh when he falls in love with a trapeze artist (Solveig Dommartin). Wenders' profoundly moving and often magical modern fairytale is an extraordinary essay on the weight of history and memory. Shifting between black-and-white and colour, it evokes both Capra's It's a Wonderful Life and Powell and Pressburger's A Matter of Life and Death. Now itself a significant artefact of a soon-to-be united Berlin, it features Nick Cave and the Bad Seeds, Crime & the City Solution, Curt Bois and Peter Falk. Co-written by Peter Handke and shot by Henri Alekan.

9:20 pm

THE STATE OF THINGS
Wim Wenders (1982) 121 mins – M

Described by Wenders as a dark investigation into his profession, this low budget, noirish art-imitates-life work came about when he discovered a film production (Raúl Ruiz's severely troubled The Territory) stalled for lack of funds. Offering to help fix things if he could use the crew to make a film – immediately – Wenders created this brilliant film-within-a-film about a remake of a Roger Corman (cameo alert!) apocalyptic science-fiction B-movie that has, unsurprisingly, stalled due to a lack of funds and film stock. Featuring Samuel Fuller, Allen Garfield and Viva.

WEDNESDAY 8 APRIL

Persons of Interest: The Independent Film Work of Haydn Keenan and Esben Storm

Esben Storm (1950–2011) and Haydn Keenan (1951–) met each other at University High in Melbourne in the late 1960s, going on to produce a series of award-winning short films that demonstrated their unflinching and fiercely independent approach to cinema. Emerging just prior to the official launch of the "revival", their low-budget first feature 27A (1974) – produced by Keenan and written and directed by Storm – is one of the major films of its era. Receiving acclaim at the Sydney Film Festival, it also won the AFI Awards for Best Fiction Feature and Best Actor. Featuring an extraordinary lead performance by Robert McDarra, it established Keenan (the youngest producer to ever win the AFI award) and Storm as two of the key young voices in Australian cinema. Although they maintained a close relationship, Storm left their production company, Smart Street Films, to make his follow up feature In Search of Anna (1978). Across the rest of his career, he completed two further features but mainly worked on television shows including Round the Twist (1992-2001) and Kick (2007). Keenan went on to direct and produce short films, documentaries, TV movies and two fiction features, Going Down (1982) and Pandemonium (1987). Although not widely seen at the time, Going Down is now regarded as one of the most vibrant and underrated Australian films of its era and provides a fascinating portrait of inner-city Sydney in the early 1980s. Keenan's career has sustained Smart Street Films as one of Australia's longest-lived production companies. His subsequent work has included documentary portraits of Reg Mombassa, Ross Hannaford and Aboriginal activist Sam Watson. He also wrote and directed the important documentary series Persons of Interest (2014), exploring the declassified ASIO files of figures such as Frank Hardy and Gary Foley. This program celebrates the tenacious work of Storm and Keenan by screening recent restorations of their two most celebrated features, 27A

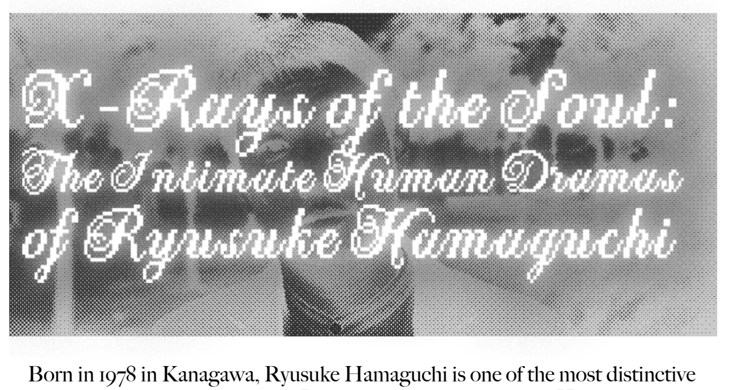
27A
7:00 pm
Esben Storm (1974) 86 mins – M

Winner of the AFI Awards for Best Feature and Actor, Storm and producer Haydn Keenan's audacious first feature was made when both were in their early 20s. A key film of the Australian feature film "revival", it is an incendiary portrait of the mental health system and "a reflection of the society that built it" (Storm). A middle-aged alcoholic (Robert McDarra, in an extraordinary lead performance) is given a six-week sentence for a minor offence and becomes trapped in a cycle of incarceration and abuse when he volunteers for psychiatric treatment and is subjected to section 27A of Queensland's Mental Health Act. With Bill Hunter and Richard Moir.
To be introduced by the film's producer, Haydn Keenan.

GOING DOWN
8:50 pm
Haydn Keenan (1982) 94 mins

Since its self-distribution to little fanfare, this fiercely independent cult classic – following four women friends on an odyssey of heady excess through a realistically depicted inner-city Sydney on their final night together before one of them leaves for New York – has been too rarely screened. Celebrated by critics such as John Flaus, Meaghan Morris and Adrian Martin, the latter calling it "one of the finest and most memorable films made in Australia", Keenan's film gained further distinction by featuring early-career performances from local bands including Pel Mel and Dynamic Hepnotics. With Tracy Mann, Julie Barry, David Argue and Esben Storm. With Bill Hunter and Richard Moir.
4K restoration to be introduced by the film's director and producer, Haydn Keenan.

15-29 APRIL



X-Rays of the Soul: The Intimate Human Dramas of Ryusuke Hamaguchi

Born in 1978 in Kanagawa, Ryusuke Hamaguchi is one of the most distinctive cinematic voices to emerge from Japan in the new millennium. His cerebral, dialogue-driven and often purposively digressive films probe the mysteries of others' inner lives, the performativity of identity and the veracity of memory, in works that bend and stretch cinema's narrative possibilities.

After completing a degree in aesthetics at the University of Tokyo in 2003, followed by a brief stint in commercial production, Hamaguchi returned to post-graduate film studies in 2008, during which he was mentored by J-horror maestro Kiyoshi Kurosawa. His thesis film, the love-triangle drama Passion (2008), earned early comparisons to Jacques Rivette, Eric Rohmer and John Cassavetes. Now a critically lauded Oscar winner (for 2021's Drive My Car) and a regular fixture in some of the most prestigious international film festivals, Hamaguchi has gone on to develop a meticulous and immersive cinematic style that combines minimalist realism with fraught and tumultuous emotions. As Manohla Dargis writes, "Hamaguchi's touch – delicate, precise, restrained, gentle – overwhelms in increments".

This season brings together work predating the breakthrough of Drive My Car, from his early medium-length films Like Nothing Happened (2003) and I Love Thee For Good (2009) to lesser-seen features, such as The Depths (2010) and The Sound of Waves (2012, co-directed with Ko Sakai), and the internationally acclaimed Asako I & II (2018) and Wheel of Fortune and Fantasy (2021).

15 APRIL
Wednesday

7:00 pm

WHEEL OF FORTUNE AND FANTASY
Ryusuke Hamaguchi (2021) 121 mins – M

Released in the same year as the widely celebrated Drive My Car, and itself awarded the Silver Bear at the 71st Berlinale and acclaimed by Cahiers du cinéma, Hamaguchi's intimate triptych presents three separate tales highlighting the nature of coincidence and fate amidst unrequited romance, seduction and misunderstanding. Although each section is imbued with a profound emotional complexity, Hamaguchi handles these female-centred stories with an imaginative and affective delicacy that is both evocative and deeply engaging.

9:20 pm

LIKE NOTHING HAPPENED
Ryusuke Hamaguchi (2003) 43 mins – Unclassified 15+

This program brings together two medium-length works from Hamaguchi's early career. His second film was shot on 8mm while the director was still a student at the University of Tokyo. Structured around a series of unhurried conversations between five young friends – one of which is played by Hamaguchi himself – it already contains many of the themes and formal elements that would come to define his cinema. Followed by the TV project I Love Thee For Good Ryusuke Hamaguchi (2009) 58 mins – Unclassified 15+. A young couple's impending marriage is threatened by the bride's secret.

22 APRIL
Wednesday

7:00 pm

ASAKO I & II
Ryusuke Hamaguchi (2018) 119 mins – M

Hamaguchi's follow up to his widely acclaimed critical breakthrough, 2015's marathon Happy Hour, is a faithful adaptation of a 2010 novel by Tomoka Shibasaki. Erika Karata plays Asako, a modern young woman who lives first in Osaka and then in Tokyo. When these two distinctly different chapters of Asako's life suddenly blur together we glimpse the fickle and complex nature of romantic love. An examination of the female gaze and feminine desire that the Guardian's Peter Bradshaw called an arresting and "amusing essay in amorous delusion". With Masahiro Higashide.

9:15 pm

THE DEPTHS
Ryusuke Hamaguchi (2010) 121 mins – Unclassified 15+

A Korean fashion photographer (Kim Min-Joon) on assignment in Japan is drawn into a fraught triangle with his old friend (Soji Arai) and a young male escort (Hoshi Ishida), as desire and professional curiosity start to blur. An early feature, this Korean-Japanese co-production already shows Hamaguchi's feel for relationships and desires built around glances, misread signals and half-spoken needs. The palpable queer tension threads through conversations that never fully align, with mistranslations and tonal slips underlining the film's unease.

29 APRIL
Wednesday

7:00 pm

TOUCHING THE SKIN OF EERINESS
Ryusuke Hamaguchi (2013) 54 mins – Unclassified 15+

This haunting tale of loneliness follows Chihiro (Shota Sometani) who, overwhelmed with grief after his father's death, channels his emotions into dance. Driven by a lyrical, flowing sense of rhythm, movement and tactile intimacy, Hamaguchi's evocative drama provides a fascinating angle on screen performance. With Hoshi Ishida and renowned choreographer Osamu Jareo. Preceded by Heaven is Still Far Away Ryusuke Hamaguchi (2016) 38 mins – Unclassified 15+. A melancholy yet hopeful ghost story partly made as a reward for contributors to the crowdfunding campaign that facilitated the production of 2015's Happy Hour.

8:45 pm

THE SOUND OF WAVES
Ryusuke Hamaguchi and Ko Sakai (2012) 142 mins – Unclassified 15+

This first and most expansive entry in Hamaguchi and Sakai's four-part series on the 2011 Tohoku earthquake presents firsthand accounts from survivors while exploring how tsunamis have helped form the region's cultural fabric. Marking a turning point in Hamaguchi's understanding of the camera's relationship to its subjects, this documentary cycle was partly made in reaction to Clint Eastwood's Hereafter – released in Japan in the days after the earthquake – with the director reflecting that "my goal was to place a camera in the middle of a tsunami in a way that was different".

6-2 MAY

A Woman of Her Time: Julie Christie

It is significant that Julie Christie (1941–) rose to fame in England in the early 1960s, a country on the cusp of social change. In one of her earliest and most emblematic roles, she played the youthful, vivacious Liz in John Schlesinger's much-admired Billy Liar (1963). Confidently swinging her handbag and smoking cigarettes, she didn't just dream of leaving her humdrum surroundings, she got on a train and left. As John Walsh wrote 50 years later: "It's a movie that vividly heralded the Sixties world of freedom, romance and escape", an emerging sensibility embodied by Christie's character.

A rising international star, her next breakout role was in Schlesinger's modish Darling (1965), shot in London, Paris and Rome, and winning Christie the Best Actress Oscar. She ensured that her character had a "look" carefully matched to the locations, and when the film became a major hit in America her "British New Wave" style took the country by storm. The press crafted a narrative of rebellion and adventure around her, and she became a role model for a generation of women seeking a modern feminist identity – thoughtful, as well as independent and sexually autonomous.

These early roles established Christie as an emblem of the "Swinging Sixties", but this dominant public image de-emphasised her considerable gifts as an actor. The quality of her work is demonstrated by the varied and often-adventurous films she went on to make in the late 1960s and 1970s, including roles as the vulnerable, conflicted young upper-class woman in Losey's The Go-Between (1971), as the haunted and suggestible mother in Roeg's Don't Look Now (1973) and, most indelibly and touchingly, as the matter-of-fact, world-weary madam in Altman's McCabe & Mrs. Miller (1971).

In the 1980s, Christie increasingly turned down high-profile roles in favour of auteur-driven projects and engaged deeply with the question of how to maintain her feminist principles in a highly gendered industry. The Gold Diggers (1983) was a critical turning point for Christie and director Sally Potter, using the star's influence to convince the BFI Production Board to finance the making of a radical feminist film with an all-female crew.

Christie continues to act into her 80s, with significant roles over the last three decades, most memorably as a woman slowly "lost" to Alzheimer's in Sarah Polley's heartbreaking Away from Her (2006). This season profiles six key performances by one of the defining actors of modern cinema.

6 MAY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

DARLING
John Schlesinger (1965) 128 mins – M

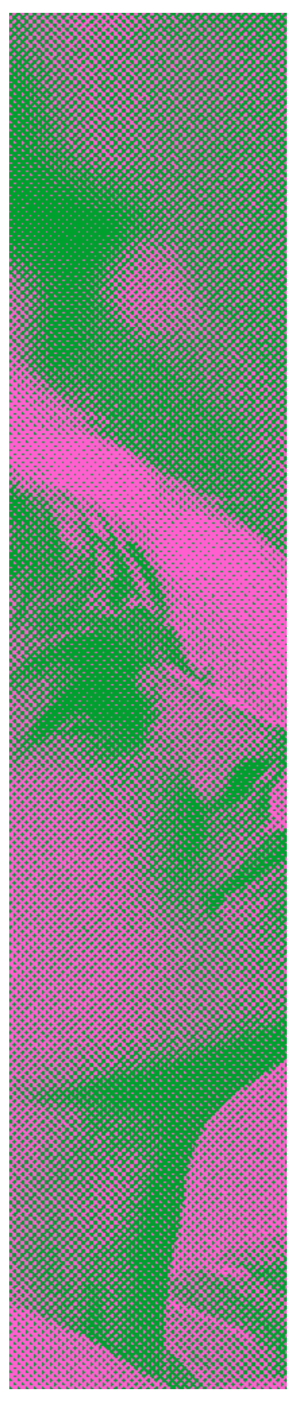
Christie's iconic performance as an ambitious yet fickle-minded model (Diana Scott) in Schlesinger's romantic drama won her international recognition, including the BAFTA and Academy awards for Best Actress. Schlesinger's cynical take on the emerging consumer society of "Swinging Sixties" London follows Diana's ascendancy up the social scale as she toys with the affections of two older men: a TV reporter (Dirk Bogarde) and an advertising executive (Laurence Harvey). The film's moral ambiguity and frank sexuality marked a turning point in the acceptance of permissive subjects in mainstream cinema. Music by John Dankworth.

4K DCP.

9:25 pm

BILLY LIAR
John Schlesinger (1963) 98 mins – PG

An intriguing time capsule in which Wenders asks various filmmakers to enter a hotel room, turn on the camera and answer the "simple" question: "Is the cinema a language about to get lost, an art about to die?" Filmed at the 1982 Cannes Film Festival, it features candid and playful responses from Michelangelo Antonioni, Jean-Luc Godard, Werner Herzog, Steven Spielberg, Monte Hellman, Mike De Leon, Susan Seidelman, Yilmaz Güney, Rainer Werner Fassbinder and others. Preceded by Reverse Angle: Ein Brief aus New York Wim Wenders (1982) 17 mins – Unclassified 15+. Wenders' essay film about New Wave music, New York, his artistic practice and the difficulties of working with Francis Ford Coppola on Hammett.



13 MAY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

MCCABE & MRS. MILLER
Robert Altman (1971) 121 mins – M

A brothel entrepreneur (Warren Beatty) joins forces with an opium-addicted madam (Julie Christie, in a wonderfully modulated performance). Altman's sleety folk Western is one of his most affecting and sadly humanistic films. Loosely based on Edmund Naughton's novel, Altman's moody masterpiece is an extraordinarily atmospheric and intemperate portrait of frontier life, the rise of modern capitalism and the "beautiful losers" who populate his greatest work. Hauntingly scored with songs by Leonard Cohen, it also features Shelley Duvall, Michael Murphy and Keith Carradine. Cinematographer Vilmos Zsigmond pre-flashed the film stock to create the evocative, de-saturated images; Pauline Kael called it a "beautiful pipe dream of a movie".

4K DCP.

9:15 pm

THE GO-BETWEEN
Joseph Losey (1971) 116 mins – MA 15+

Christie plays a romantic young aristocrat in this exquisitely judged English pastoral drama set at the end of the Victorian era (where the past is indeed a "foreign country"). Seemingly resigned to the overwhelming influence her social class will have on her future, she confides in a schoolboy who visits for the summer holidays. In L. P. Hartley's novel, the boy's narration as an old man frames the story, but Harold Pinter's brilliant adaptation also uses a flashforward technique to undercut the tale's nostalgia. Winner of the 1971 Cannes Palme d'Or, its wonderful cast also includes Alan Bates, Edward Fox, Michael Redgrave and Margaret Leighton. Music by Michel Legrand.

4K DCP.

20 MAY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

THE GOLD DIGGERS
Sally Potter (1983) 89 mins – G

Made with an entirely female crew and partially shot in Iceland by Babette Mangolte (Akerman's Jeanne Dielman...), this landmark of 1980s feminist counter-cinema emerged from a unique moment in film history. When the film's protagonist (Christie) has to try to recollect her memories in order to discover who (or what) she is, the viewer shares her labour in putting the fragments together. An inventive and provocative fantasy of song and dance featuring an abundance of allegorical motifs, forking narratives and cinematic riddles, its wilfulness and "determination to laugh in the face of [male] power" (So Mayer) unsettled many contemporary critics.

8:45 pm

AWAY FROM HER
Sarah Polley (2006) 110 mins – M

Christie was nominated for an Academy Award for her "career-defining performance" (Jonathan Rosenbaum) as a woman whose diagnosis of early-onset Alzheimer's disease reveals a wedge in her marriage to Grant (Gordon Pinsent). Tender scenes are set against an idyllic snowbound landscape, made picturesque so as to underline the cruelties of ageing. Adapted from a short story by Alice Munro, Polley's debut feature is a small-scale drama and an actor's showcase, with Christie's career-capping performance standing out. With Olympia Dukakis and Michael Murphy.

35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

27-10 MAY - JUNE

No One Here Gets Out Alive: Johnnie To, Dancing While the Building Burns

Johnnie To (1955–) began his career in Hong Kong TV as a 17-year-old, starting out as a messenger while studying acting in the evenings ("I didn't want to be an actor. My training... was just a stepping stone to directing.") Over a decade of experience working his way up through various production roles provided him with an unusually grounded sense for how scenes work in practice, using casts and crews with little patience for mystique. A tentative 1979 debut was followed by a permanent shift into filmmaking in the mid-1980s, though his early features remained stifled by the studio system – co-directing assignments and jobs for hire for powerful, interventionist producers such as Tsui Hark and Stephen Chow.

In 1995, To formed his own production company – Milkyway Image – in collaboration with writer-producer Wai Ka-Fai, asserting that "it was time to be a director, not an engineer". This new-found autonomy, the post-1997 handover financial crisis, and the departure of senior figures like Hark, John Woo and Ringo Lam for Hollywood allowed To the space to develop what has since become his authorial signature: genre films focusing on characters and shot through with operatic flourishes that belie their surprisingly low budgets; a use of close-to-hand locations (often in and around his own office and studio); and extremely economical shooting schedules.

An astonishing 33 completed features between 1995 and 2009 testify to the discipline and leanness of To's directorial approach. Balancing competing cinematic influences – the emotional expressiveness of Martin Scorsese ("my favourite director"), Akira Kurosawa ("a god") and Jacques Demy with the spare, minimalist interiority of Kieślowski, Kobayashi and, especially, Melville – what emerges is a romanticised fatalism, where codes of honour and loyalty drenched in potent cinematic mythologies are tempered by a sober reckoning with the more realistic and banal elements of criminal life. His action scenes, built from behaviour and character – who yields, who hesitates, who acts decisively – are as elegantly choreographed as his occasional forays into musicals, and contain emotional resonances which linger in our bodies long after the dust has settled on their protagonists.

27 MAY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

ELECTION
Johnnie To (2005) 101 mins – MA 15+

Featuring a large ensemble cast led by Tony Leung Ka-Fai and Simon Yam as two opposing gang leaders engaged in a vicious struggle for power, To's defining film brought a fresh perspective to the Hong Kong crime genre with its sobering, unromanticised view of the criminal underworld and the corruption within it. Often cited as To's magnum opus, the film premiered in competition at the 2005 Cannes Film Festival and went on to become a success in Hong Kong and around the world. Winner of Best Film, Best Director, Best Actor and Best Screenplay at the Hong Kong Film Awards.

35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

9:00 pm

EXILED
Johnnie To (2006) 110 mins – M

A quartet of hitmen in pre-handover Macau find the bonds of friendship tested when they fall on opposite sides in their latest assignment. An elegiac mix of ritual, camaraderie and impending doom – staged with To's typical feel for pauses, hesitations and sudden eruptions – the film showcases his regular ensemble playing in brilliant harmony, with Anthony Wong most fully embodying the film's bruised humour and weary grace. The widescreen frame turns every room into a pressure chamber, a space for a melancholic dance between loyalty and inevitability that plays closer to Peckinpah or Leone than to a contemporary gun opera. With Simon Yam.

35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

3 JUNE
Wednesday

7:00 pm

RUNNING ON KARMA
Johnnie To and Wai Ka-Fai (2003) 93 mins – MA 15+

Andy Lau, donning an impressive muscle suit, won Best Actor at the Hong Kong Film Awards for his turn as a monk-turned-bodybuilder who teams up with Cecilia Cheung's cop. A supernatural buddy movie that defies genre categorisation, To's tenth collaboration with co-director Wai indulges in a kinetic visual palette and stylised action choreography to create a highly entertaining confection. While it may be "one of the looniest high concepts to date" (Variety's Derek Elley), its enriching spirituality and Buddhist themes grant it a truly rewarding depth.

35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

8:45 pm

LIFE WITHOUT PRINCIPLE
Johnnie To (2011) 107 mins – M

A financial thriller built from intersecting strands – a small-time gangster scrambling for relevance, a loan officer nudged into predatory sales, and an overextended cop circling the fallout. Part of the post-GFC trickle of "we should've seen this coming" cinema, To's mix of low-key absurdity and criminal opportunism is as much ironic farce as cautionary tale. Ordinary people collapse under forces they barely grasp, and capitalism reveals itself as just another of To's rigged games, exposing the moral fault lines of everyone from swaggering crooks to bewildered pensioners.

35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

10 JUNE
Wednesday

7:00 pm

THROW DOWN
Johnnie To (2004) 96 mins – M

Released during To's most deliriously prolific period of filmmaking between 2001 and 2005, this convention-breaking martial-arts comic drama is set amidst the hidden bars and neon-lit nightclubs of Hong Kong's underworld. Claimed by To as his tribute to Akira Kurosawa's first film, Sanshiro Sugata, it has an unsurprisingly high number of beautifully choreographed and impactful fight scenes. Louis Koo plays an alcoholic bar owner and former judo champion who is challenged by a young rival (Aaron Kwok). This odd couple meet up with Mona (Cherrie Ying), a wannabe pop star.

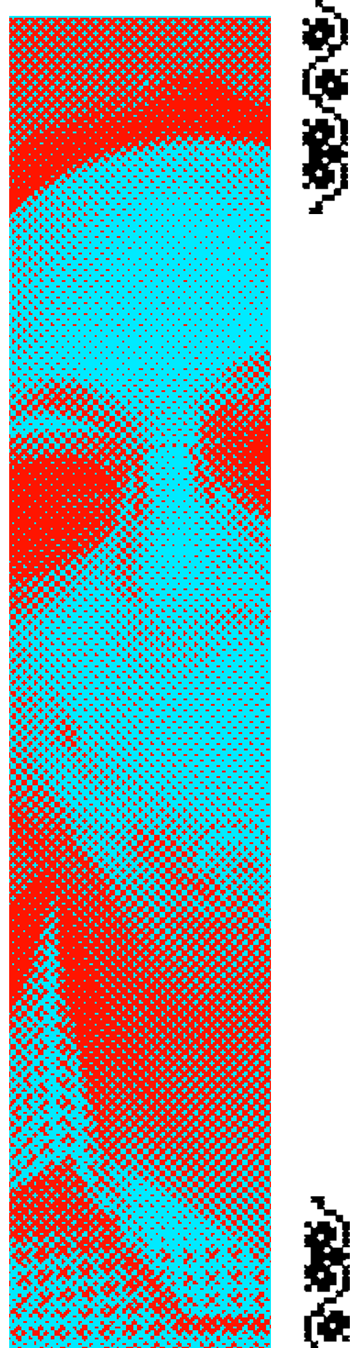
35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

8:45 pm

RUNNING OUT OF TIME
Johnnie To (1999) 93 mins – M

A dying master criminal (Andy Lau) seeking revenge on the crime syndicates ingeniously enlists a police inspector (Lau Ching-Wan) as his unwitting accomplice. To's ultra cool and hyper-stylised contemporary thriller pays distinct homage to the cinema of Jean-Pierre Melville while also leading the way towards key later works of Hong Kong crime cinema like the Election and Infernal Affairs series. Completed in fits and starts over a period of two years, this emotionally engaging and highly inventive take on the heist subgenre illustrates why David Bordwell called To "the most versatile talent" in Hong Kong cinema, with the best "track record since John Woo and Tsui Hark".

35mm print.



8-22 JULY

By Any Means Necessary: Spike Lee, American Provocateur

Born in Atlanta, Georgia, and raised in Brooklyn, New York, Spike Lee (1957–) is one of the United States' most prolific and provocative auteurs, amassing a filmography of more than 20 narrative features alongside numerous documentary projects, television shows and music videos. After graduating from Atlanta's Morehouse College in 1979, and establishing his production company 40 Acres and a Mule Filmworks, Lee enrolled in the Graduate Film Program at New York University, where he was classmates with Jim Jarmusch and Ang Lee.

As an up-and-coming independent filmmaker in the 1980s, Lee was an integral figure of the "New Black Cinema". His low-to-mid budget commercial hits of this time such as She's Gotta Have It (1986) and Do the Right Thing (1989) grappled with the complexities of Black cultural identity, racism, endemic violence and gender dynamics in unapologetically direct, combative and confronting ways. Through a vibrant cinematic language of saturated colours, double-dolly shots, pastiche and fourth-wall-breaking direct address, Lee has developed a practice defined by a "creatively restless experimentation with theme, image, directorial style, camera shots [and] social issues", all "while not being committed to a particular genre" (Ed Guerrero).

This season highlights the wide-ranging scope of Lee's oeuvre, traversing pressing political, cultural and social issues facing America through some of its most significant historical events of the last 60 years including the 1963 16th Street Baptist Church bombing in 4 Little Girls (1997) and the aftermath of 9/11 in 25th Hour (2002). Surveying a range of Lee's work across fiction and documentary, it profiles some of his most celebrated films, such as BlacKkKlansman (2018), alongside key but lesser-known works like School Daze (1988), Crooklyn (1994) and Summer of Sam (1999).

8 JULY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

SCHOOL DAZE
Spike Lee (1988) 121 mins – M

The unexpected critical and commercial success of Lee's low budget first feature, She's Gotta Have It, persuaded Columbia Pictures to put up $6 million for his second. With an entirely Black cast, Lee's rarely revived film examines heterogenous identities in a Southern all-Black college, styled as a 1940s Technicolor musical. The conflicts, contradictions, politics and class divisions of 1980s Black America are dissected through sharp dialogue and lavish song and dance sequences. Starring Laurence Fishburne and a rich cast of Lee regulars including Giancarlo Esposito, Samuel L. Jackson, Ossie Davis, Bill Nunn and Lee himself.
4K DCP.

9:20 pm

25TH HOUR
Spike Lee (2002) 135 mins – MA 15+

In post-9/11 New York, a drug dealer (Edward Norton) moves through his final day of freedom, surface swagger giving way to regret and reckoning. Norton's typical narcissism is perfectly utilised by Lee, who buttresses him with a stacked ensemble – Philip Seymour Hoffman, Brian Cox, Rosario Dawson, Anna Paquin – helping generate pathos for an unlikeable man through the reactions and empathy of those around him. Lee's feel for street-level detail, sudden bursts of anger and the raw, unsettled mood of a city whose confidence has been shattered, transforms David Benioff's occasionally ranting screenplay into a bruised, strangely tender hymn to New York's endurance.
35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

15 JULY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

BLACKKKLANSMAN
Spike Lee (2018) 135 mins – MA 15+

Loosely based on Ron Stallworth's 2014 memoir, Lee's most celebrated 21st-century feature follows the extraordinary true story of a pair of undercover African-American and Jewish police officers (played by John David Washington and Adam Driver) who infiltrate the Ku Klux Klan in Colorado Springs in the late 1970s. Co-produced by Jordan Peele and co-written by Lee (winning his first competitive Oscar), and pointedly opening with a famous shot from Gone With the Wind romanticising the plight of the South, this potent comic drama was a significant commercial success and features a stellar supporting cast, including Harry Belafonte in his final film role.

9:30 pm

CROOKLYN
Spike Lee (1994) 114 mins – M

Lee enlisted his siblings Joie and Cinqué to co-write this sentimental account based on their upbringing in 1970s Bed-Stuy, starring Delroy Lindo as a musician father and Alfre Woodard as a teacher and mother. Featuring a dense soul and pop soundtrack. and a joltingly unusual use of anamorphic cinematography from Arthur Jafa, the film is – according to Lee – "a love letter to the mother we all lost at a young age". Zelda Harris stands out as the only daughter amongst four brothers, alongside a gaggle of neighbourhood eccentrics played by David Patrick Kelly, RuPaul, Lee himself and numerous others.

22 JULY
Wednesday

7:00 pm

4 LITTLE GIRLS
Spike Lee (1997) 102 mins – M

Initially intended as a feature drama, Lee's first documentary had been percolating since 1983 when he wrote to the father of Carol Denise McNair, one of the girls (alongside Addie Mae Collins, Cynthia Wesley and Carole Robertson) murdered in the Ku Klux Klan's 1963 16th Street Baptist Church bombing in Birmingham, Alabama. Eventually earning the victims' families' trust, Lee decided the story was best told through non-fiction. The resulting chronicle of four young lives cut short is a brilliant and understandably sombre document, supported by a thematically appropriate soundtrack featuring John Coltrane, Joan Baez and Max Roach.
35mm print courtesy of the National Film and Sound Archive, Australia.

8:55 pm

SUMMER OF SAM
Spike Lee (1999) 142 mins – R 18+

Lee's take on the infamous "Son of Sam" murders – in which serial killer David Berkowitz went on a 13-month spree in New York City, killing six people and wounding eleven – focuses on the events' erosion of trust between the residents of a largely Italian-American neighbourhood in the Bronx during the late 1970s. Criticised at the time of release for its profanity and violence, this maximalist crime thriller's portrait of white America "now seems nuanced, sympathetic, and tragically prophetic" (Jackson Arn). With John Leguizamo, Mira Sorvino, Adrien Brody and Lee himself as a TV reporter.

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